The IB men asked how many times I had been to Pakistan. I said I have travelled to virtually every country, but not Pakistan. That was the truth. Making it evident that their foreign masters either did not have full information about my Ural Aviation adventure or did not give the full picture to these men, they said, 'We know the Ural Aviation flight that took off from Moscow landed in Karachi before coming to India.' I did not question the stupidity of the idea that I would escort a cargo flight carrying the cryogenic parts to India.

Further questions exposed their pre-determined plot to link me to Pakistan.

'Who is your best friend?'

'Prasad.'

'No, no. We want the name of a Muslim friend.'

I started seeing the plot.

'A P J Abdul Kalam.'

The first blow from one of the men standing behind me caught me off guard. I struggled to keep my balance, and braced for more torture.

'Now don't be too smart,' barked one of the interrogators, 'Give us another Muslim name.'

'Mohammed Yousuf Khan, my childhood friend.'

'Where is he now?'

'I don't know.'

'Then give us another name, a Muslim name, with whom we can inquire about you.'

After a minute of thinking, I named Abubaker, a friend from Palayamkottai in Tamil Nadu. Soon I realised that I could be unnecessarily putting him in danger. Later I realised that the IB had prepared stock names of ISI agents and they wanted similar sounding names to be linked to me.

Now blows showered on me. Enduring a sense of disorientation after the first few hits, I resolved to stand my ground, and challenged my tormentors to do whatever, but I would not endorse their fabricated story of spying. They were about to leave, saying the interrogation would continue the next day, when I told them: